

In the process, George protects the community from the greedy bank director and slum landlord, Henry F. Potter (Lionel Barrymore).

Shocking decline

George's rapid transition from saint to suicidal drunk is shocking and credible, perhaps rooted in Capra's own struggle with depression in his early twenties, when, as an Italian immigrant, he found work difficult to come by. Years of self-sacrifice and disappointment lie behind George's breakdown, and as a portrait of despair his downward spiral is utterly compelling.

George and Uncle Billy (Thomas Mitchell, second from right) celebrate at the close of business on the day of the bank run. With \$2 left, they are still in business.

While contemporary audiences may have been put off by the story's divine intervention, Capra's movie wasn't so much about magic realism as tragic realism: the angel doesn't appear at the bridge until the movie's final quarter. Another director might have focused more on the drama that makes George want to end his life, but Capra keeps it from us, not so that it becomes a mystery but because, when we do find out, it adds to the pathos of a man trying to do right.

On the brink

Potter is the villain of the piece. When George realizes that his uncle Billy has mislaid \$8,000 of

the townspeople's money, he goes to Potter—his lifelong enemy—to negotiate a loan. George has nothing but a life insurance policy to offer as collateral, and Potter sneers at him: "You're worth more dead than alive." Within this loaded insult lies one of the movie's main tenets: just as one life can make all the difference, so can its absence.

In despair, George drives to the toll bridge to jump to his death. The movie's most famous moment doesn't occupy much of its running time but it sticks in the memory for its darkness. Wishing aloud that he'd "never been born," George is taken by Clarence to a parallel reality, one in which George never existed, and where

